THE BATTLE OF NAVARINO

In July 1827 Britain, France, and Russia signed the Treaty of London, agreeing joint action to end the war in Greece, where Greek nationalists were fighting for independence from the Ottomans. The British commander-in-chief in the Mediterranean, Sir Edward Codrington, was ordered to demand that both sides observe an immediate armistice.

In September an Egyptian fleet from Alexandria anchored in Navarino Bay, the principal Ottoman naval base in the Peloponnese. Nominally part of the Ottoman Empire, Egypt had achieved a notable degree of modernization under French influence and its navy was now superior to the Turkish fleet. Admiral Codrington blockaded the harbor and sought assurances that the Egyptian ships would not be used against the Greeks. Nonetheless the ships twice sortied out of the bay and had to be shepherded back into port by Codrington.

In October Codrington was joined by the French admiral Henri de Rigny and the Russian admiral Login Heyden, creating an allied force of 10 ships of the line plus a 60-gun frigate, de Rigny's flagship *Sirène*. Hoping to avoid a prolonged winter blockade, the admirals agreed on a bold plan of action: they would sail into the bay and anchor opposite the Ottoman-Egyptian fleet, whose commanders would be forced either to implement an armistice or have their fleet destroyed.

NO WAY BACK

At 2 p.m. on October 20, Codrington's flagship *Asia* led two columns of British and French ships into the harbor, with the Russians following in the rear. It was on the face of it a desperately risky operation. The allied ships sailed between shore batteries to anchor in the middle of a horseshoe-shaped formation of Ottoman and Egyptian ships, with an onshore wind making any escape from the bay virtually impossible. But the allied commanders' faith in the superiority of their guns and gunnery was well founded.

Asia anchored with a band playing on deck, hoping the Ottomans and Egyptians would not put up resistance.

In fact the fighting started almost immediately. Conducted at close range in a crowded harbor, the cannonade of the allied ships proved fearsomely effective. The Turks and Egyptians fought with courage and determination, but they lacked both adequate guns and training. Codrington's *Asia* took on the Ottoman flagship and an Egyptian 60-gun frigate simultaneously and shattered both. It was the same story elsewhere: three-quarters of the Ottoman and Egyptian ships were sunk by enemy gunfire or by their own crews, who set them on fire or blew them up to avoid them falling into enemy hands.

The news of the Ottoman defeat at Navarino was greeted with joy by the Greeks and with defiance by the Ottoman sultan, who declared a jihad against the infidel. This precipitated a war with Russia, which the Ottomans lost, and Greece eventually gained its independence. The battle is above all remembered as the last major naval encounter of the sailing ship era.



Smoothbore naval gun
Smoothbore naval guns remained in use until late in the 19th century. They were superseded by rifled breech-loaders.



